

# CISC 3667: Game Design and Development

## In-Class Activity 1: Is it a Game?

**Assigned:** Thursday, September 3

### Objective

In this activity, you will explore the question:

### **What makes something a game?**

You will first examine different activities using four definitions of a game.

Then, you will **redesign an ordinary activity into a game** by adding game elements.

The goal is not to find one "correct" definition of a game. Instead, you will see how different definitions can lead to different conclusions, and how game designers can use goals, rules, challenges, feedback, and interaction to transform an activity into a game.

### Part 1: Is It a Game?

**Step 1: With your assigned group of 4-5 students, choose 2-3 activities from the following:**

- Walking to class
- Doing homework
- Cleaning your room
- Cooking a meal
- Shopping
- Studying for an exam
- Exercising
- Waiting in line
- Drawing
- Playing with LEGO
- Solving a crossword puzzle
- Watching a movie
- Watching a sports game
- Using social media
- Rock, Paper, Scissors
- Tag
- A scavenger hunt
- A slot machine
- Make-believe

Some of these are clearly games, while others are intentionally **debatable**.

## Step 2: Discuss Your Activity

For each activity, discuss:

- Is this a game? Why or why not?
- What characteristics make it feel like a game?
- What characteristics might prevent it from being considered a game?

There may not be one correct answer.

Focus on **supporting your reasoning**.

## Part 2: Apply the Four Definitions

Use the four definitions discussed in class.

### Kevin Maroney

A game is a form of play with **goals and structure**.

### Jane McGonigal

A game includes:

- A goal
- Rules
- A feedback system
- Voluntary participation

### Jesse Schell

A game is a **problem-solving activity approached with a playful attitude**.

### Chris Crawford

A game is an **interactive, goal-oriented activity** in which players or active agents can interfere with one another.

## Analyze Each Activity

Complete the following table for each activity.

**Activity:** \_\_\_\_\_

| Definition | Does it qualify as a game?                                                              | Why or why not? |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Maroney    | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |
| McGonigal  | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |
| Schell     | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |
| Crawford   | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |

## Part 3: Turn an Activity Into a Game

Now you will become the **game designer**.

Choose **one activity that your group believes is not clearly a game**, or that does not satisfy one or more of the definitions, and **turn the activity into a game**.

You may add, remove, or change elements of the activity as needed.

Modify your activity so that it **qualifies as a game under one or more of the four definitions**, as clearly as possible.

## Part 4: Design Your Game

Create a short description of your redesigned game.

Your group should answer the following:

- **Original Activity**
  - What activity did you start with?
- **What Was Missing?**
  - Why did the original activity **not clearly qualify** as a game under your chosen definition(s)?
- **Your Changes**
  - What did you **add or change** to turn it into a game?
- **Your New Game**
  - Give your game a **name** and briefly describe how it is played.

## Part 5: Test Your New Game Based on All Definitions

Now apply the four definitions to your **redesigned game**.

| Definition       | Does it qualify as a game?                                                              | Why or why not? |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| <b>Maroney</b>   | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |
| <b>McGonigal</b> | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |
| <b>Schell</b>    | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |
| <b>Crawford</b>  | <input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No <input type="checkbox"/> Maybe |                 |

Compare this table with your original activity.

## Final Discussion

After the activity, consider:

- Can an activity be a game under one definition but not another?
- **What elements are essential to making something a game?**

## Key Takeaway

**There is no single universal definition of a game.**

Different definitions emphasize different aspects of what games are and how they work.

As game designers, we can use these ideas to think critically about the experiences we create and the ways players engage with them. Understanding what makes something a game is only the beginning. The next question is: **what makes playing it enjoyable?**